MODERN JOURNALISM: TRENDS, NEW FORMATS, AND SOCIAL MEDIA DEVELOPMENT WITHIN THE POLITICAL LINE OF PRESIDENT ILHAM ALIYEV

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Abstract**:** This article examines the key trends of modern journalism, the emergence of new media formats, and the growing influence of social media on public opinion within the framework of President Ilham Aliyev's political strategy. The study analyzes the President's public speeches and media engagements related to media policy, information security, digital transformation, transparency, and state–media relations using a theoretical and analytical approach. The main objective of the article is to identify the political and ideological foundations of transformations occurring in Azerbaijan's media landscape and to academically assess the strategic communication model shaped by President Ilham Aliyev in response to contemporary media challenges, particularly in the context of social media expansion and information warfare.

Keywords: modern journalism, social media, new media formats, media policy, President Ilham Aliyev

Introduction

The twenty-first century has fundamentally transformed the nature of journalism. Rapid advances in information technologies, the expansion of digital platforms, and the rise of social media as a dominant channel of mass communication have reshaped classical journalistic models. These developments require new approaches to state information policy, media freedom, and national information security. In Azerbaijan, the development of modern journalism has been carried out in a consistent and systematic manner within the political line of President Ilham Aliyev. President Ilham Aliyev has repeatedly emphasized the strategic importance of information in the contemporary world. In his interview with CNN International on 1 October 2020, he stated: "Today, information warfare is an integral part of real warfare, and we must also be victorious in this domain." This statement reflects the conceptual framework underlying Azerbaijan's modern media policy.

Key Trends in Modern Journalism

Modern journalism is characterized by several interrelated trends:

• Digitalization and multimedia integration, combining text, video, audio, and infographics;

• Speed and immediacy, enabling real-time dissemination of information;

• Interactivity, fostering direct engagement between media and audiences;

• Personalized content, tailored to audience interests;

• Information security and ethical responsibility, particularly in combating disinformation.

President Ilham Aliyev has consistently highlighted that information confrontations have become a central element of global competition. This perspective positions journalism not merely as a transmitter of news, but as a strategic sector responsible for safeguarding national interests.

New Media Formats and the State Communication Model

New media formats—online news portals, social networks, podcasts, and video-sharing platforms—have reshaped state–society communication. During President Ilham Aliyev's tenure, relations between state institutions and the media have been strengthened at an institutional level, with increased emphasis on professional press services and transparent communication mechanisms. The open dissemination of the President's official speeches, interviews, and international media engagements demonstrates a commitment to transparency and accountability. This approach ensures that Azerbaijan's positions are accurately conveyed to both domestic and international audiences.

Social Media and Political Communication

Social media has become an indispensable component of modern journalism. Within President Ilham Aliyev's political strategy, social media functions as a critical instrument of information policy. At the III Shusha Global Media Forum on 14 July 2021, held in the city of Shusha, the President emphasized: "Achieving superiority in the information space is one of the key elements of national security, and modern media must recognize this responsibility. The rapid dissemination of official information through digital platforms plays a vital role in countering misinformation and ensuring timely public awareness, particularly in an environment where false narratives spread quickly.

Social Media and Information Warfare

In the contemporary era, information warfare has emerged as a decisive tool of interstate rivalry. During the 44-day Patriotic War, President Ilham Aliyev's numerous interviews with leading international media outlets served as a central pillar of Azerbaijan's information strategy. In his interview with BBC News on 22 October 2020, he stated: "We are telling the truth. Truth and international law are on our side."

The wide circulation of these interviews on social media platforms significantly contributed to

Azerbaijan’s information superiority and influenced international public opinion. This experience demonstrated that when guided by a coherent strategy, social media can become a powerful instrument for defending national interests.

Media Policy, Ethical Responsibility, and Information Security

President Ilham Aliyev has consistently advocated for a free yet responsible media environment. Speaking at an event dedicated to the 147th anniversary of the Azerbaijani National Press on 19 July 2022 in Baku, he noted: “A free media is one of the pillars of a strong state, but this freedom must be aligned with professional ethics and national interests.” Accordingly, enhancing journalistic professionalism, strengthening media literacy, and preparing a new generation of journalists capable of responding to modern challenges constitute key priorities of Azerbaijan’s state media policy.

Conclusion

The analysis demonstrates that the development of modern journalism in Azerbaijan has been guided by a strategic and conceptual approach within the political line of President Ilham Aliyev. Digitalization, the adoption of new media formats, the effective use of social media, and preparedness for information warfare constitute the core pillars of the country’s information policy. President Ilham Aliyev’s media engagements, open dialogue with international journalists, and emphasis on information security have shaped the trajectory of contemporary Azerbaijani media. His approach—grounded in truth, legality, and national interests—has strengthened Azerbaijan’s voice in the global media environment. Thus, President Ilham Aliyev’s political line may be regarded as a comprehensive model that responds to the challenges of modern journalism, reinforces state–society communication, and safeguards national interests amid the realities of social media expansion and information warfare.

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